MODERN WISDOM READING LIST VOL.2

100 MORE BOOKS TO READ BEFORE YOU DIE

WELCOME

Hi friend,

As an avid non-reader who couldn’t sit still without a phone in his hands only a few years ago, it takes a lot to hold my attention and all 100 titles on this list do so magnificently.

This is not supposed to be a list of the 100 greatest books of all time (I already wrote a Vol. 1 list which also didn't meet that criteria) but rather the books which have impacted my worldview and entertained me the most. Consider it an extensive but not exhaustive syllabus to improve your life. The list is purposefully not grouped by subject. Go exploring into new areas.

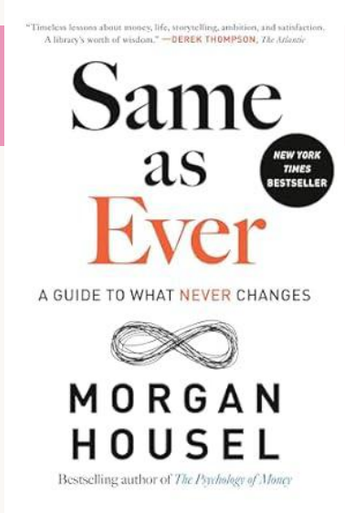
I hope you fall in love with these books as much as I did.

Chris x

MUST READS

SAME AS EVER: A GUIDE TO WHAT NEVER CHANGES

Morgan Housel



Life Lessons, Psychology, History

Phenomenal. A really stark assessment of how to gauge risk, seize opportunity and live your best life. Engaging stories and pithy examples. Superbly easy read. Will help you to be more broad-sighted and focus on what is permanently true.

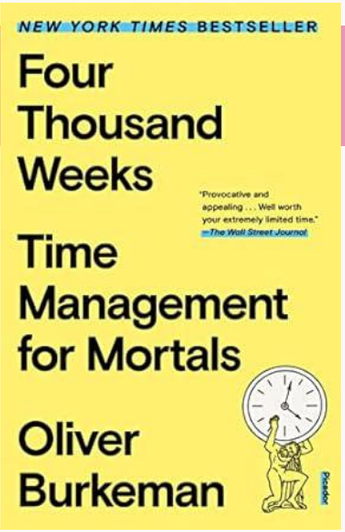
Buy On Amazon

FOUR THOUSAND WEEKS: TIME MANAGEMENT FOR MORTALS

Oliver Burkeman

Time Management, Mindful Productivity Self-Deprecating

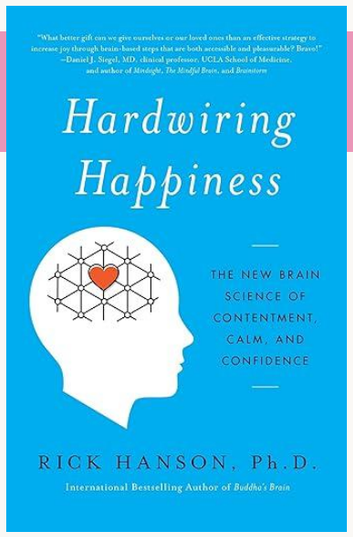
The ultimate reminder that you're going to die and not complete your To Do List from my favourite productivity writer. If you find yourself feeling overwhelmed by your work-load and need to reframe, this is for you. Simple, philosophically insightful, realistic. Outstanding.



Buy On Amazon

HARDWIRING HAPPINESS: THE NEW BRAIN SCIENCE OF CONTENTMENT, CALM, AND CONFIDENCE

Dr. Rick Hanson



Neuroscience, Gratitude, Happiness-Science

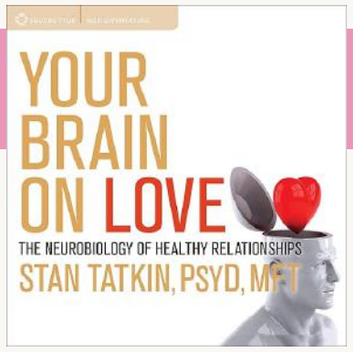
The best evidence-based guide to becoming a happier person. A very simple breakdown of how happiness manifests within the brain and a straightforward set of instructions about how you can bring more of it into your life. Must read.

Buy On Amazon

YOUR BRAIN ON LOVE: THE NEUROBIOLOGY OF HEALTHY RELATIONSHIPS

Dr. Stan Tatkin

Relationships, Attachment, Mindful Dating

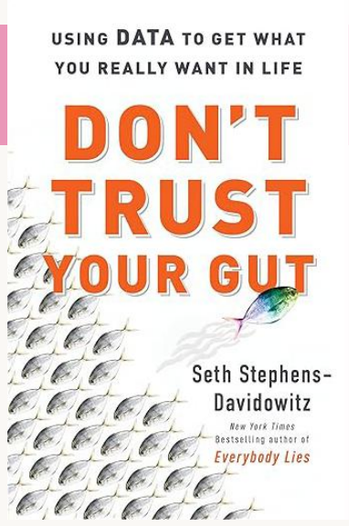


The best book on attachment I've ever found. Super simple to understand. Wildly insightful. Plain language. Amazing advice on how to overcome disagreements, better understand your partner, be in deeper connection and upgrade your relationship.

Listen on Audible

DON'T TRUST YOUR GUT: USING DATA TO GET WHAT YOU REALLY WANT IN LIFE

Seth Stephens-Davidowitz



Buy On Amazon

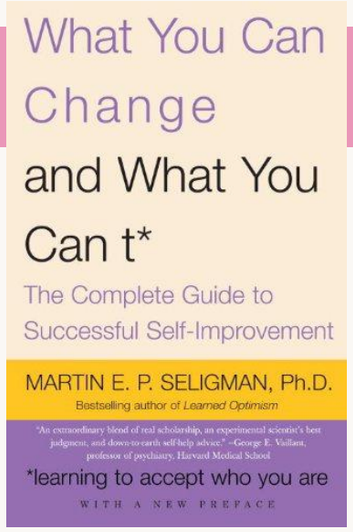
Personal Development, Psychology, Data-Driven Advice

A must read. Seth uses huge datasets to help answer life's biggest questions with evidence. What should you do if you want to be more attractive? When is the best time in life to start a business? How happy does it actually make you to skip a friend's birthday party for a night of Netflix on the couch? Which boring careers produce the most wealth?

NON FICTION

WHAT YOU CAN CHANGE... AND WHAT YOU CAN'T*: THE COMPLETE GUIDE TO SUCCESSFUL SELF-IMPROVEMENT

Martin Seligman



Behavioural Genetics, Personal Development, Realistic Improvement

The daddy of positive psychology with a great book breaking down the limits of self-improvement. How much do our genes limit and enable us? What strategies and areas should we try to improve and which are dead ends?

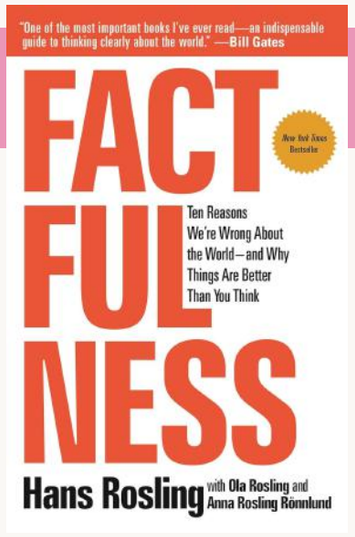
Buy On Amazon

FACTFULNESS: TEN REASONS WE'RE WRONG ABOUT THE WORLD - AND WHY THINGS ARE BETTER THAN YOU THINK

Hans Rosling

Global Trends, Evidence-Based, Human Progress

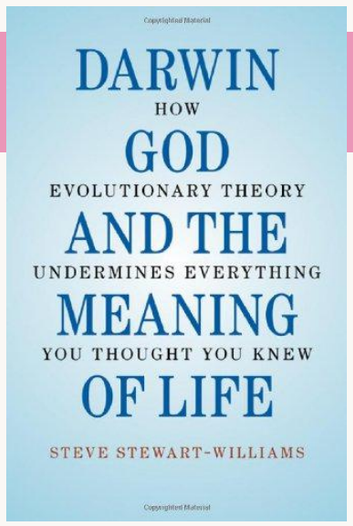
The world is less horrible than you believe and here is a book to give you some evidence that proves it. Inspiring and revelatory. It's got lively anecdotes and moving stories. Will empower you to respond to the crises and opportunities of the future.



Buy On Amazon

DARWIN, GOD AND THE MEANING OF LIFE: HOW EVOLUTIONARY THEORY UNDERMINES EVERYTHING YOU THOUGHT YOU KNEW

Steve Stewart-Williams



Evolutionary Psychology, Life Meaning, Deep Insight

Love evolutionary psychology? Love happiness research? Love thinking about what constitutes a good life? Mix them together and you've got this beauty by Steve. Super accessible. A fantastic blend of meaningful, deep insight and evolutionary theory.

Buy On Amazon

ELON MUSK

Walter Isaacson

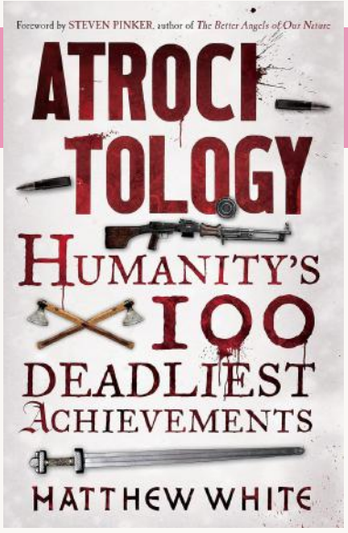
Biography, Resilience, Motivation

Fascinating insight into one of the most unique humans of our era. Elon is a fascinating combination of driven and broken from childhood. Makes for a really great insight into just how differently humans can be constructed.

Buy On Amazon

ATROCITOLOGY: HUMANITY'S 100 DEADLIEST ACHIEVEMENTS

Matthew White



History, Graphic Retellings, Death

An 'Atrocitologist' considers man's inhumanity to man across several thousand years of history. From the First Punic War and the collapse of Mayan rule, to the reign of Peter the Great and the cataclysmic events of the Second World War, the book measures the hundred most violent events in human history. Oddly quite fun for a morbid topic.

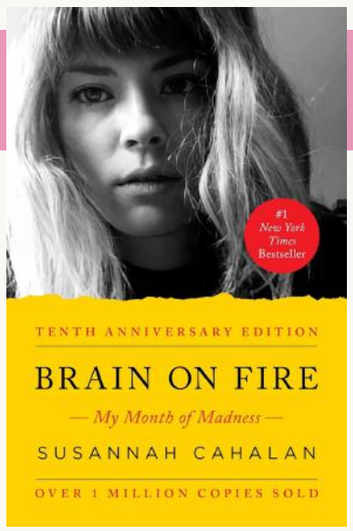
Buy On Amazon

BRAIN ON FIRE: MY MONTH OF MADNESS

Susannah Cahalan

Real Life, Psychological Disturbance, Medical Mystery

A 24 year old wakes up alone in a hospital room, strapped to her bed and unable to move or speak with no memory of how she'd gotten there. Days earlier, she had been at the beginning of her first serious relationship and a promising career at a major New York newspaper. Now she was labeled violent, psychotic, a flight risk. A personal retelling of how fragile the human brain actually is.



Buy On Amazon

NO MORE MR NICE GUY: A PROVEN PLAN FOR GETTING WHAT YOU WANT IN LOVE, SEX, AND LIFE

Dr. Robert Glover

Personal Development, Dating, Masculinity

A salve to people pleasing, being a nice guy and trying to get the world to bend to your pleasantries. Holistic, mindful and integrated masculinity come together to help guys get past feeling frustrated, confused, and resentful. If you have trouble with setting boundaries, dishonesty, codependency, people-pleasing, conflict avoidance, passive-aggressiveness, unsatisfying relationships or sexual issues - this is for you.

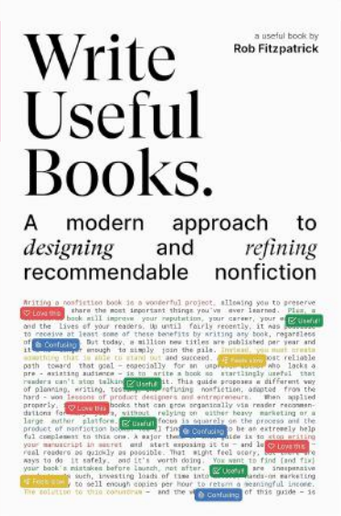
Buy On Amazon

WRITE USEFUL BOOKS: A MODERN APPROACH TO DESIGNING AND REFINING RECOMMENDABLE NONFICTION

Rob Fitzpatrick

Writing Guidance, Simple, Actionable

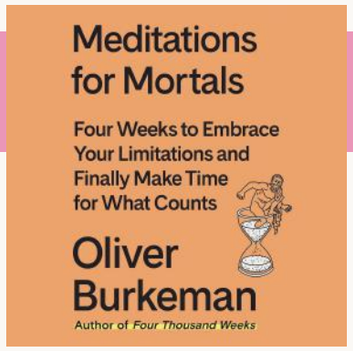
This guide proposes a different way of planning, writing, & refining nonfiction, drawn from the hard-won lessons of product designers & entrepreneurs. Applied properly, it leads to books that can grow organically via reader recommendations for many years, without relying on either heavy marketing or a large author platform.



Buy On Amazon

MEDITATIONS FOR MORTALS: FOUR WEEKS TO EMBRACE YOUR LIMITATIONS AND MAKE TIME FOR WHAT COUNTS

Oliver Burkeman



Buy On Amazon

Time Management, Self-Love, Mindful Productivity

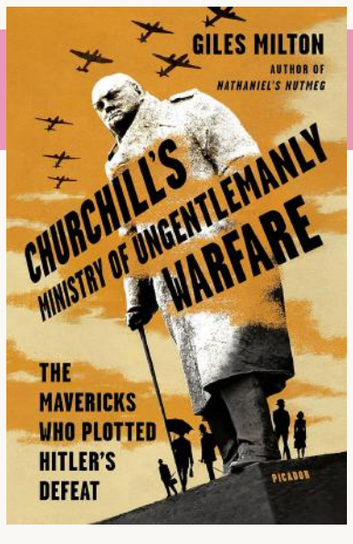
A crash course in living more fully for insecure overachievers. A map for a liberating journey toward a more meaningful life which addresses the fundamental questions about how to live well. A combination of practical tools and daily shifts in perspective. Must read.

CHURCHILL'S MINISTRY OF UNGENTLEMANLY WARFARE: THE MAVERICKS WHO PLOTTED HITLER'S DEFEAT

Susannah Cahalan

History, World War 2, Entertaining

The book that birthed the movie. Such a great retelling of some of the weirdest, most secretive guerrilla campaigns of Britain's wartime mavericks. Highly recommended on Audible for additional British-accent-immersion. Very enjoyable.



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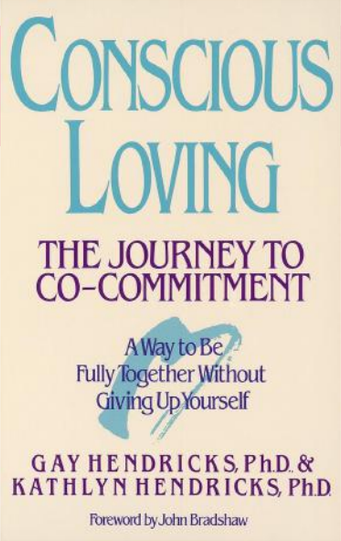
CONSCIOUS LOVING: THE JOURNEY TO CO-COMMITMENT

Gay Hendricks



Relationships, Self-Work, Mindful Dating

Precise strategies to help you create a vital partnership and enhance the energy, creativity, and happiness of your relationship. Learn how to let go of power struggles and need for control, balance needs for closeness and separateness, increase intimacy by telling the "microscopic truth", communicate in a positive way that stops arguments, make agreements you can keep and allow more pleasure into your life.

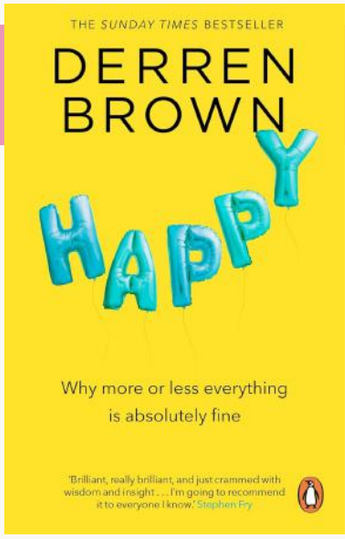
Buy On Amazon

HAPPY: WHY MORE OR LESS EVERYTHING IS FINE

Derren Brown

Stoicism, Happiness Psychology, Self-Development

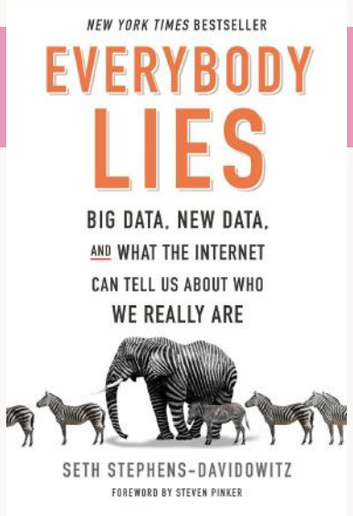
Everyone says they want to be happy. But that's much more easily said than done. What does being happy actually mean? And how do you even know when you feel it? Derren Brown shows how many of self-help's suggested routes to happiness and success – such as positive thinking, self-belief and setting goals – can be disastrous to follow and, indeed, actually cause anxiety.



Buy On Amazon

EVERYBODY LIES: BIG DATA, NEW DATA, AND WHAT THE INTERNET CAN TELL US ABOUT WHO WE REALLY ARE

Seth Stephens-Davidowitz



Buy On Amazon

Psychology, Statistics, Human Nature

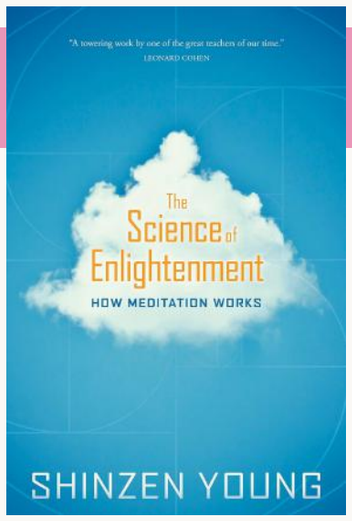
A fascinating insight into what big data tells us about ourselves. We Google search things we daren't even tell our partner or ourselves. Does where you go to school effect how successful you are in life? Do parents secretly favour boy children over girls? Do violent films affect the crime rate? Can you beat the stock market? How regularly do we lie about our sex lives and who's more self-conscious about sex, men or women?

THE SCIENCE OF ENLIGHTENMENT: HOW MEDITATION WORKS

Shinzen Young

Meditation, Mindfulness, Self-Development

Shinzen is one of my favourite meditation teachers. Unbelievably precise, simple, secular and non-technical in explaining the key elements of a good meditation technique. A must read for anyone wanting to get into meditation.



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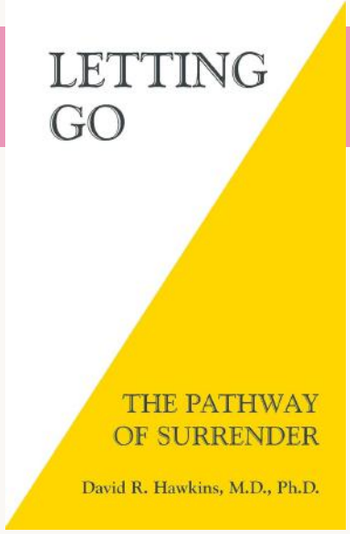
LETTING GO: THE PATHWAY OF SURRENDER

Dr. David R. Hawkins



Mindfulness, Meditation, Releasing

A practical technique to remove the inner blocks to happiness, love, joy, success, health, and, ultimately, enlightenment. A psychiatrist & meditation teacher provides a mechanism for letting go of life's biggest blocks.

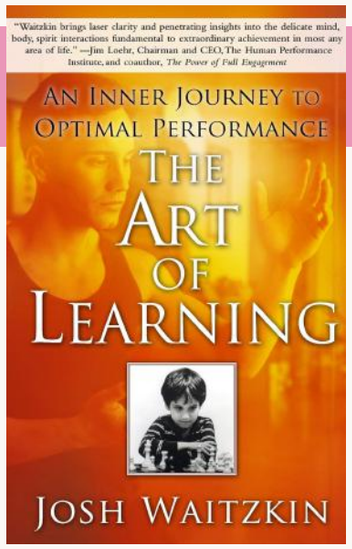
Buy On Amazon

THE ART OF LEARNING: AN INNER JOURNEY TO OPTIMAL PERFORMANCE

Josh Waitzkin

Personal Development, Learning, Self-Improvement

Legendary book about a chess prodigy who leaves the game to become a world champion in multiple other pursuits. Philosophical, deep, empowering. Good any time you need to give your motivation a kickstart.



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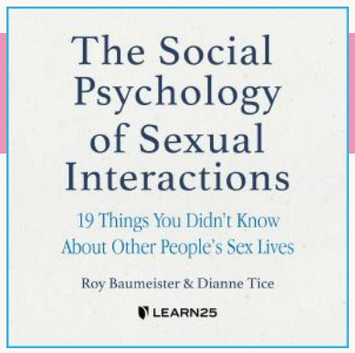
THE SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY OF SEXUAL INTERACTIONS: 19 THINGS YOU DIDN'T KNOW ABOUT OTHER PEOPLE'S SEX LIVES

Roy Baumeister



Listen on Audible

Sex, Relationships, Evolutionary Psychology

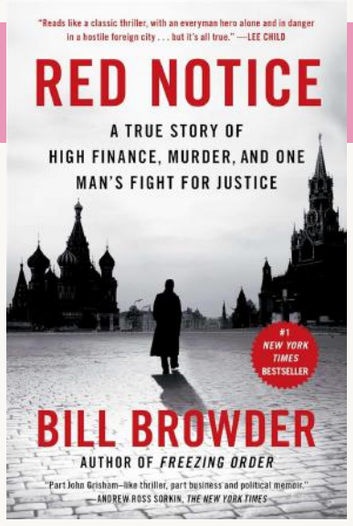
A scientific vantage on human sexuality. 19 short lectures on some fascinating topics about sex such as: Do men really want to have sex more than women? Who is actually having lots of sex, and why? How has the internet changed sexual behaviour? Why have so many societies tried to stifle female sexuality?

RED NOTICE: A TRUE STORY OF HIGH FINANCE, MURDER, AND ONE MAN'S FIGHT FOR JUSTICE

Bill Browder

Soviet Russia, Memoir, Financial Crime

A spectacular retelling of Bill Browder's journey to become Putin's number one enemy as he tried to expose Russia's regime. Filled with financial back-biting, political intrigue and mortal danger. Fun and quick paced.



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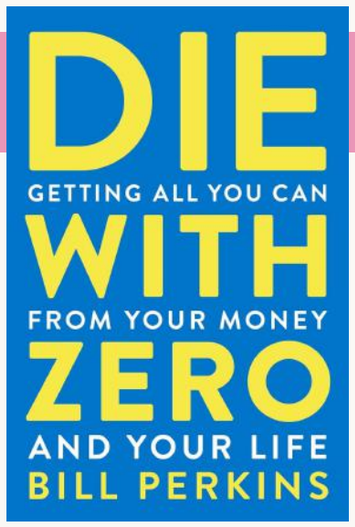
DIE WITH ZERO: GETTING ALL YOU CAN FROM YOUR MONEY AND YOUR LIFE

Bill Perkins



Life Philosophy, Financial Strategy, Fun-Creating

One of the best books I've read on how to actually use your money well. If you always feel guilty spending money, have no idea how to use your money well and don't want to waste your life working so you never enjoy it, this is for you. Super short and impactful.

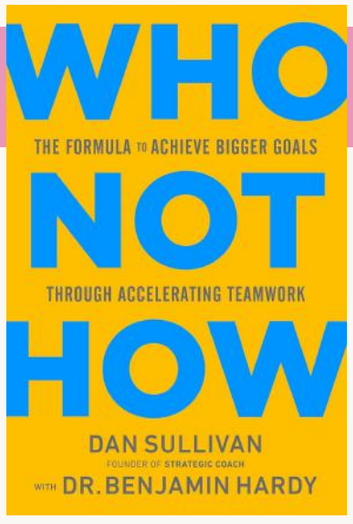
Buy On Amazon

WHO NOT HOW: THE FORMULA TO ACHIEVE BIGGER GOALS THROUGH ACCELERATING TEAMWORK

Dan Sullivan & Dr. Benjamin Hardy

Team-Building, Delegation, Business Advice

A really important paradigm shift for people who struggle to build teams and delegate tasks to other people. If you're overly self-reliant, this is for you. Retrain your brain to stop limiting your potential.



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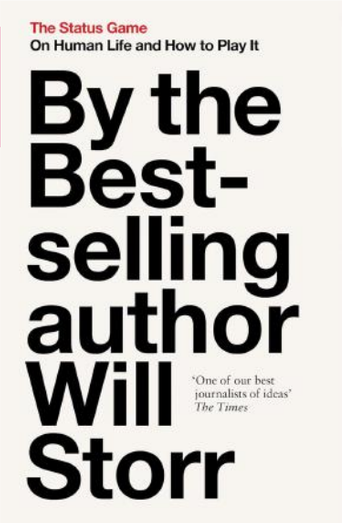
THE STATUS GAME: ON HUMAN LIFE AND HOW TO PLAY IT

Will Storr



Status, Human Nature, Psychology

Must read. How does a desire for recognition drive humans to do incredibly and terrible things. From bitter conflicts to wild dreams, status explains pretty much everything and this book is a great primer on exactly how it works filled with great stories. If you like understanding human psychology, you'll love this.

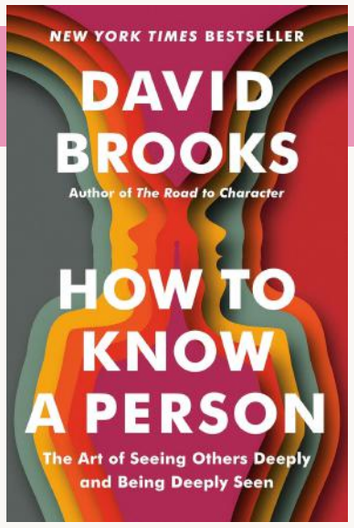
Buy On Amazon

HOW TO KNOW A PERSON: THE ART OF SEEING OTHERS DEEPLY AND BEING DEEPLY SEEN

David Brooks

Communication, Relational Skills, Emotional Openness

A blueprint for a more connected and humane way of living. Not just how to have better conversations, but a deep dive into the philosophy, neuroscience, psychology and history of connection. A wonderfully mindful and integrated approach to properly resonating with the people around you.



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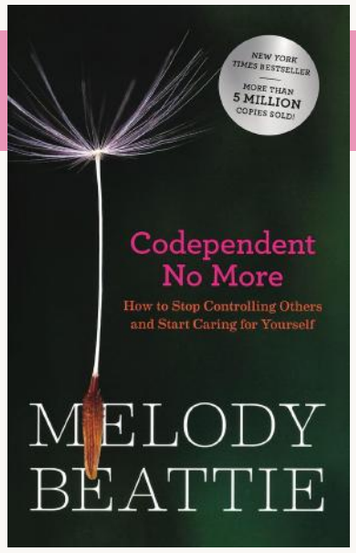
CODEPENDENT NO MORE: HOW TO STOP CONTROLLING OTHERS AND START CARING FOR YOURSELF

Melanie Beattie



Codependency, Relating, Practical Psychology

Do you find yourself not being ok if someone else is not ok? Do you lose yourself in the name of helping other people? If you see other people's problems as always your responsibility, this book is for you. Stop losing sight of your own life in the drama of tending to a loved one.

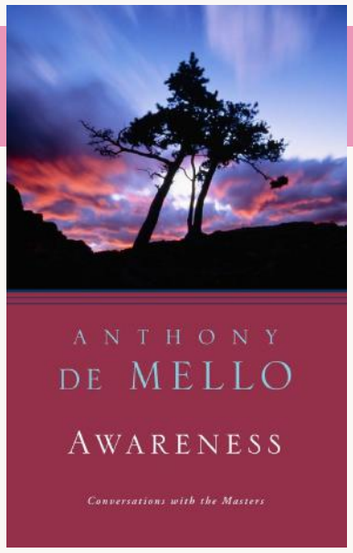
Buy On Amazon

AWARENESS: CONVERSATIONS WITH THE MASTERS

Anthony de Mello

Mindfulness, Psychology, Spirituality

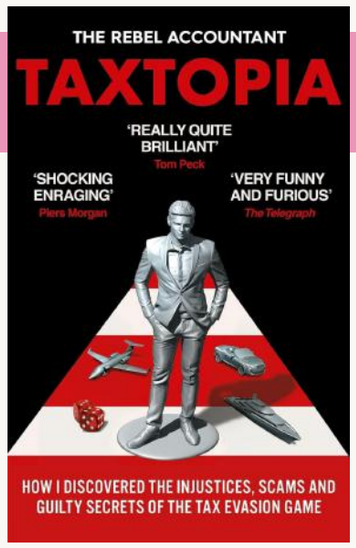
Short chapters breaking down the basics of awareness. How can you become alive to the needs and potential of others? Mixing Christian spirituality, Buddhist parables, Hindu breathing exercises, and psychological insight, de Mello's words of hope come together in this grand synthesis.



Buy On Amazon

TAXTOPIA: HOW I DISCOVERED THE INJUSTICES, SCAMS AND GUILTY SECRETS OF THE TAX EVASION GAME

The Rebel Accountant



Finance, Corruption, Humour

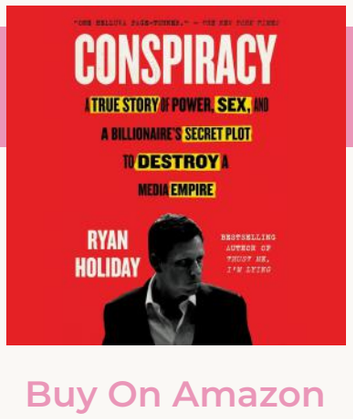
A funny breakdown of some of the craziest ways people, companies and countries evade paying tax. Equal parts fascinating, hilarious and anger-inducing. Anyone interested in how global markets and the ultra-rich work should read this.

Buy On Amazon

CONSPIRACY: A TRUE STORY OF POWER, SEX, AND A BILLIONAIRE'S SECRET PLOT TO DESTROY A MEDIA EMPIRE

Ryan Holiday

Memoir, Real Life Crime, Thriller

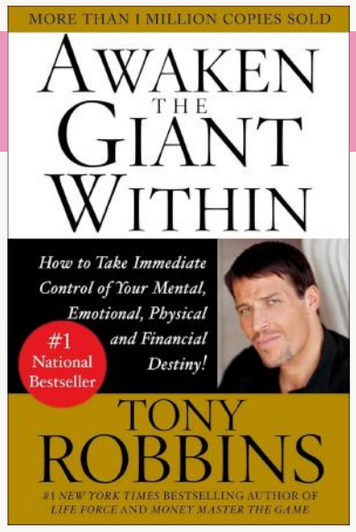


Ryan Holiday's least known, but as far as I'm concerned, best book. A breakdown of how Peter Thiel rekt Gawker after they revealed private information about him. It's got a Hulk Hogan sex tape in it, vicious legal ramifications and a ton of scandal. Must have listened to this 3 times at least. So so good.

Buy On Amazon

AWAKEN THE GIANT WITHIN: HOW TO TAKE IMMEDIATE CONTROL OF YOUR MENTAL, EMOTIONAL, PHYSICAL AND FINANCIAL DESTINY!

Tony Robbins



Mastering Change, Emotions, Human Psychology

A wonderful breakdown of the psychology of change. A step-by-step program teaching the fundamental lessons of self-mastery that will enable you to take control of your life. I personally used this to help me make some huge decisions in my life. Highly recommended.

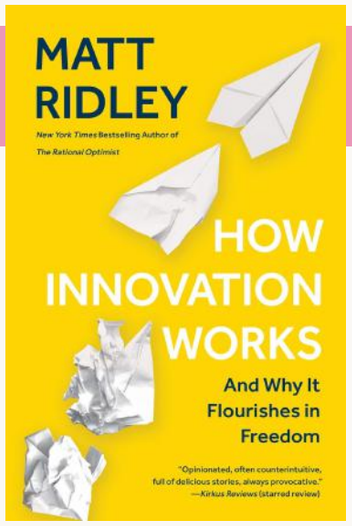
Buy On Amazon

HOW INNOVATION WORKS: AND WHY IT FLOURISHES IN FREEDOM

Matt Ridley

Technological Progress, Industry, History

A wonderful breakdown of the history of innovation including steam engines, jet engines, search engines, airships, coffee, potatoes, vaping, vaccines, cuisine, antibiotics, mosquito nets, zero, computers, dogs, farming, fire, container shipping, railways, cars, safety rules, wheeled suitcases, mobile phones, corrugated iron, powered flight, chlorinated water, toilets, vacuum cleaners and even life itself.



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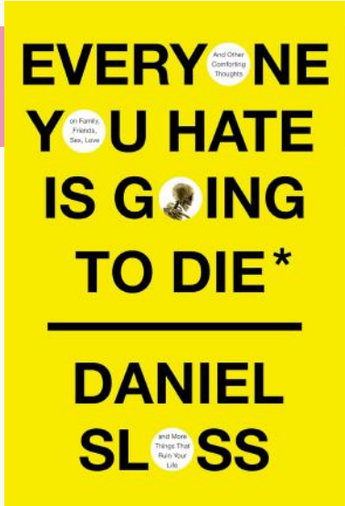
EVERYONE YOU HATE IS GOING TO DIE: AND OTHER COMFORTING THOUGHTS ON FAMILY, FRIENDS, SEX, LOVE, AND MORE THINGS THAT RUIN YOUR LIFE

Daniel Sloss



Psychology, Human Nature, Comedy

Sloss goes after every conceivable kind of relationship—with one's country, with America, with lovers, ex-lovers, ex-lovers who you hate, ex-lovers who hate you; with parents; with best friends (male and female), not-best friends; with children; with siblings; and even with the global pandemic and our own mortality. Great on Audible.

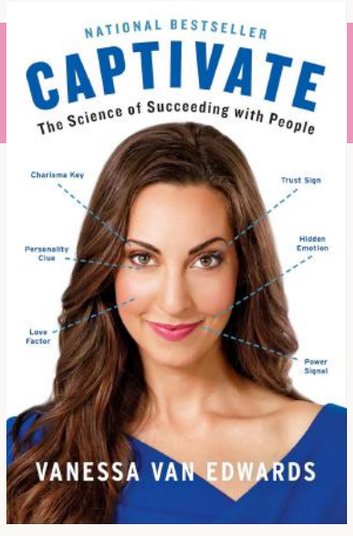
Listen on Audible

CAPTIVATE: THE SCIENCE OF SUCCEEDING WITH PEOPLE

Vanessa Van Edwards

Communication, Conversation, Body Language

How to be less awkward, appear more confident and control your body language. A great breakdown of shortcuts, systems, and secrets for taking charge of your interactions at work, at home, and in any social situation. Super practical and tactical takeaways.



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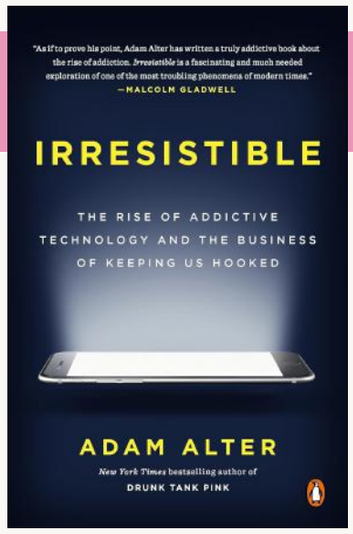
IRRESISTIBLE: THE RISE OF ADDICTIVE TECHNOLOGY AND THE BUSINESS OF KEEPING US HOOKED

Adam Alter



Technology, Psychology, Social Media

A great exploration of how technology is controlling our lives and making us behaviourally addicted. It's important to understand how these platforms and products cause us to be so compelled to use them and this is a fantastic primer.

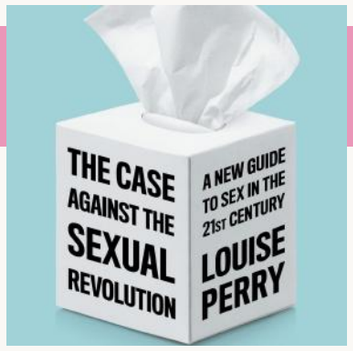
Buy On Amazon

THE CASE AGAINST THE SEXUAL REVOLUTION

Louise Perry

Counter-Culture, Feminism, Relationships

One of my favourite reads. A provocative look at the non-positive outcomes from the sexual revolution. How have women ended up being on the losing end of a sexually liberated and hyper-sexualised culture? Super short, punchy, great. Read it.



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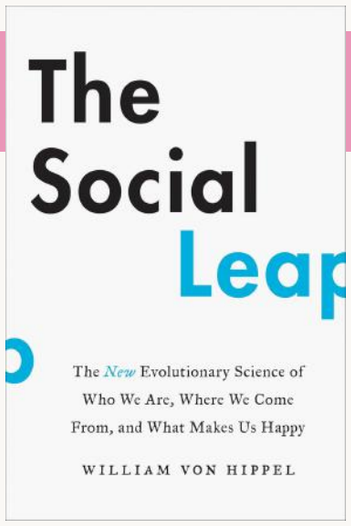
THE SOCIAL LEAP: THE NEW EVOLUTIONARY SCIENCE OF WHO WE ARE, WHERE WE COME FROM, AND WHAT MAKES US HAPPY

William von Hippel



Social Psychology, Anthropology, Evolutionary Psychology

For fans of Sapiens and Guns, Germs, and Steel. Blending anthropology, biology, history, and psychology with evolutionary science, this is a fresh and provocative look at our species. Some fascinating insights providing new clues about who we are, what makes us happy, and how to use this knowledge to improve our lives.

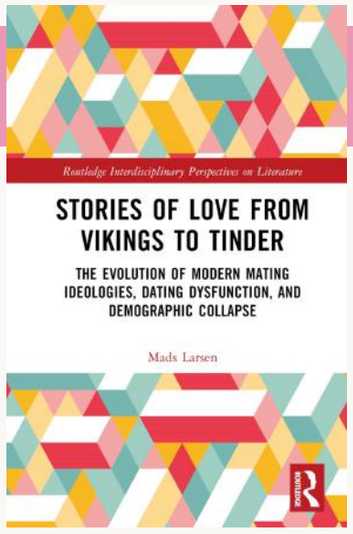
Buy On Amazon

STORIES OF LOVE FROM VIKINGS TO TINDER

Mads Larsen

Mating Dynamics, Evolutionary Psychology, Population Collapse

Such a sleeper read. A wonderful journey through the history of human romantic ideologies. From when we were hunter gatherers, to farmers marrying off our daughter to the farmer next door, to the renaissance and modern era. Fascinating. And free.



Free to Download

DO HARD THINGS: WHY WE GET RESILIENCE WRONG AND THE SURPRISING SCIENCE OF REAL TOUGHNESS Steve Magness

Buy On Amazon

Motivation, Peak Performance, Mindset

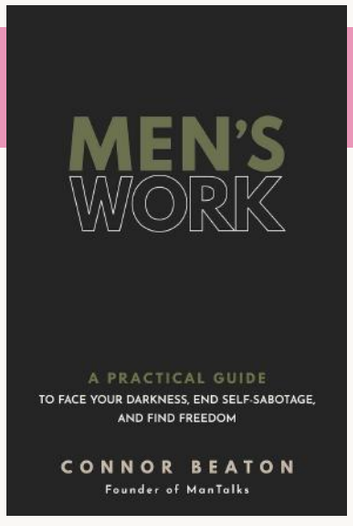
A great explanation of what true toughness is. Breakdowns of how we can work with our body, how experiencing discomfort, leaning in, paying attention, and creating space to take thoughtful action can be the true indications of cultivating inner strength. A roadmap for navigating life's challenges and achieving high performance that makes us happier, more successful, and, ultimately, better people.

MEN'S WORK: A PRACTICAL GUIDE TO FACE YOUR DARKNESS, END SELF-SABOTAGE, AND FIND FREEDOM

Connor Beaton

Masculinity, Personal Development, Confidence

One of my favourite men's writers on how to live with clear purpose and direction, build your skills to win at relationships, gain better control of your anger, learn how to regulate your mind, body and emotions, even under stress and conflict, and become fearless and at peace with your journey.



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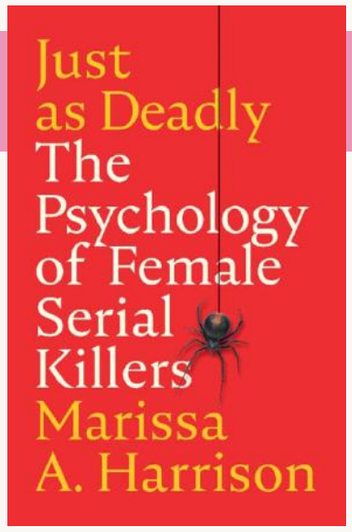
JUST AS DEADLY: THE PSYCHOLOGY OF FEMALE SERIAL KILLERS

Marissa A. Harrison



Criminal Psychology, Serial Killers, Female Mindset

1 in 6 serial killers are women but no one pays them any attention. Why do they kill? Who do they kill? What methods do they use? How are they caught? What are their motivations? Harrowing and fascinating.

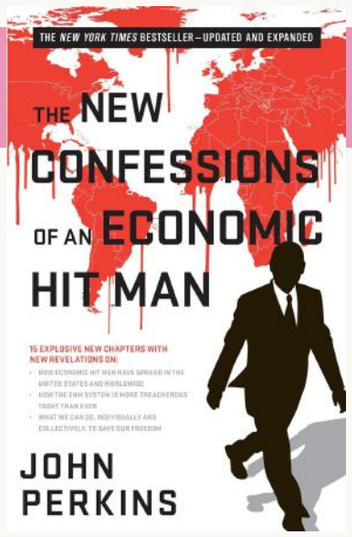
Buy On Amazon

THE NEW CONFESSIONS OF AN ECONOMIC HITMAN

John Perkins

Memoir, Corruption, Geopolitics

Former economic hit man John Perkins shares new details about the ways he and others cheated countries around the globe out of trillions of dollars. Then he reveals how this deadly method of working has spread far more widely and deeply than ever in the US and everywhere else—to become the dominant system of business, government, and society today.



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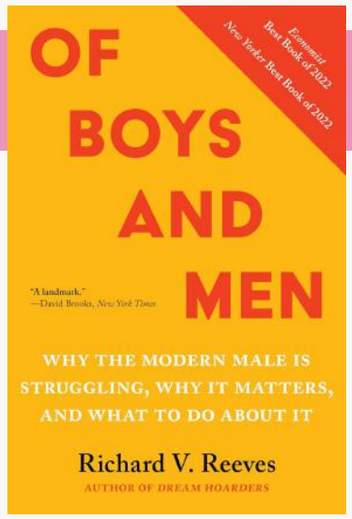
OF BOYS AND MEN: WHY THE MODERN MALE IS STRUGGLING, WHY IT MATTERS, AND WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT Richard Reeves



Masculinity, Male Issues, Psychology

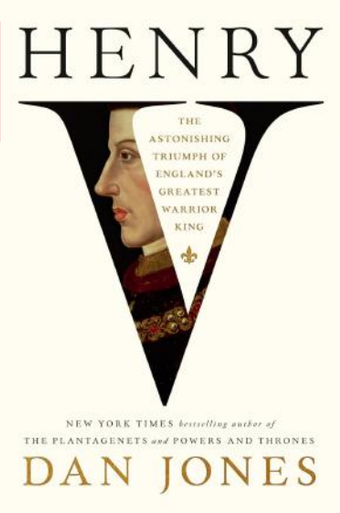
Why are boys and men falling behind? Economic and social changes of recent decades have many losing ground in the classroom, the workplace, and in the family. While the lives of women have changed, the lives of many men have remained the same or even worsened. Short, seminal. Must read.

Buy On Amazon

HENRY V: THE ASTONISHING TRIUMPH OF ENGLAND'S GREATEST WARRIOR KING Dan Jones

History, Medieval England, Humour

Britain's Marcus Aurelius gets a gorgeous treatment from one of my favourite history writers. Hilarious stories throughout, super compelling, witty. Any history nerd will love this.



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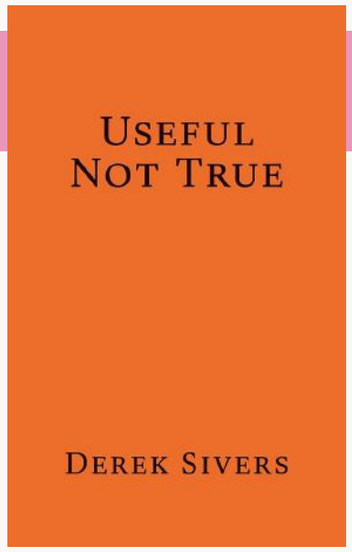
USEFUL NOT TRUE
Derek Sivers



Psychology, Life Philosophy, Deep Insight

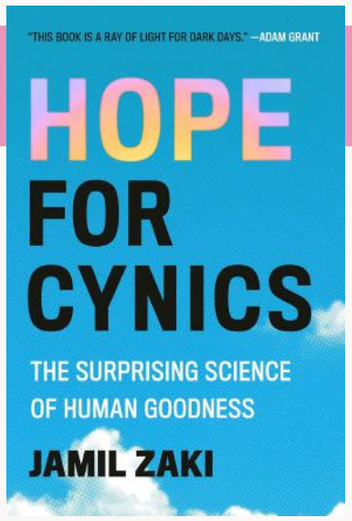
Incredibly short chapters giving some hard hitting lessons on realisations you already had a sense of but never put into words. Great life advice. For fans of The Almanack of Naval Ravikant.

Buy direct from Sivers.com

HOPE FOR CYNICS: THE SURPRISING SCIENCE OF HUMAN GOODNESS
Dr Jamil Zaki

Positivity, Psychology, Rational Optimism

The science and secrets of beating back cynicism. How to think critically about people and problems while honouring and encouraging strengths. For anyone who wants a bit more hope in their life and struggles to find the justification.



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FLUKE: CHANCE, CHAOS, AND WHY EVERYTHING WE DO MATTERS

Brian Klaas

Human History, Chaos Theory, Social Science

Phenomenal. Brian is such a great writer with a ton of varied, weird and novel stories. How much of your life was always going to turn out this way? And how much is total chance? A fundamental question asked in a totally new way.

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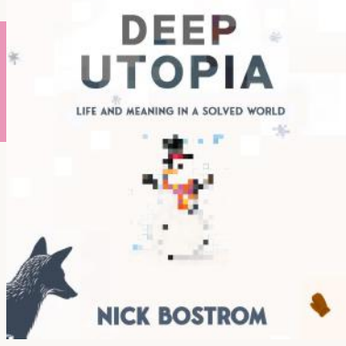
DEEP UTOPIA: LIFE AND MEANING IN A SOLVED WORLD

Nick Bostrom

Artificial General Intelligence, Far Futures, Technology

Everyone knows the concerns of AI going wrong, but what happens if it goes right? What if we live in a “solved” world where no issues exist? What problems occur then? More than you would think, apparently. So allow Nick to terrify you with them.



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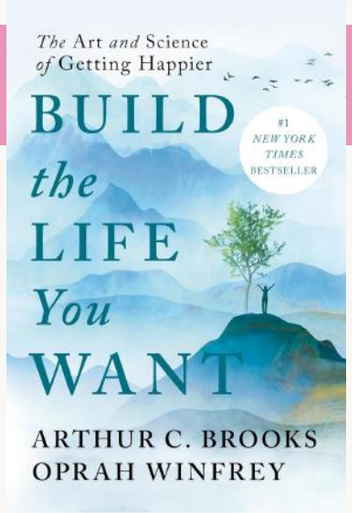
BUILD THE LIFE YOU WANT: THE ART AND SCIENCE OF GETTING HAPPIER

Arthur Brooks



Happiness, Positive Psychology, Evidence-Based

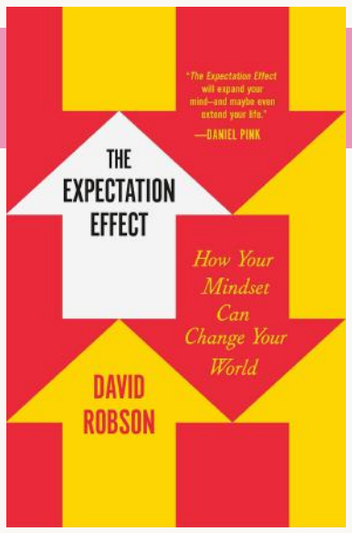
Free of waffle and unnecessary wishful thinking, this is a great breakdown of exactly how happiness works, how to design your life to get more of it and why it can be so elusive. Kind of a manual for creating a life you will value. Oprah is involved somehow too.

Buy On Amazon

THE EXPECTATION EFFECT: HOW YOUR MINDSET CAN CHANGE YOUR WORLD

David Robson

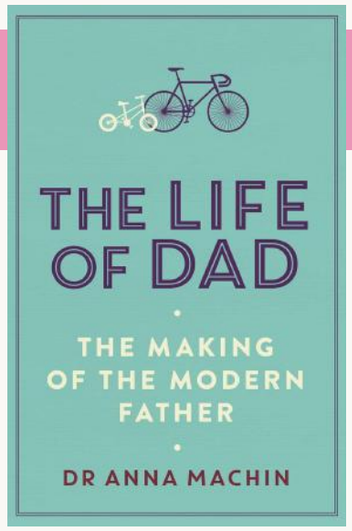
Psychology, Positivity, Personal Development



So SO good. Get on this. A journey through the cutting-edge science of how our mindset shapes every facet of our lives, revealing how your brain holds the keys to unlocking a better you. You've heard of the placebo effect and how sugar pills can accelerate healing. But did you know that sham heart surgeries often work just as well as real stents? Or that people who think they're prone to cardiovascular disease are four times as likely to die from cardiac arrest? Such is the power and deadly importance of the expectation effect—how what we think will happen changes what does happen.

Buy On Amazon

LIFE OF DAD
Dr. Anna Machin



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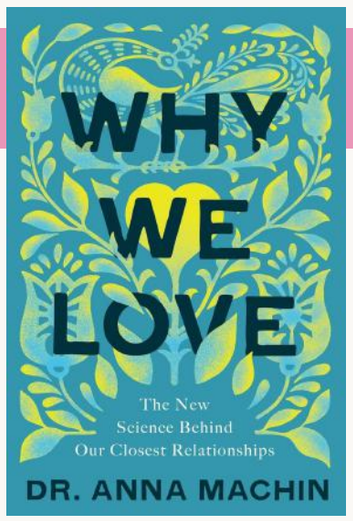
Fatherhood, Empowering Masculinity, Evolutionary Psychology

The story of fatherhood and what it means to be a father today, based on a decade-long study of new and expectant fathers. Answering questions like 'Will fatherhood change me?', 'How do other men fulfil the role?', 'How can I help my child grow into a healthy, happy adult?'. Drawing on the latest findings in genetics, neuroscience and psychology, this is an empowering beast of a book.

WHY WE LOVE: THE NEW SCIENCE BEHIND OUR CLOSEST RELATIONSHIPS
Dr. Anna Machin

Mating Dynamics, Human Psychology, Science Of Romance

An Oxford-trained evolutionary anthropologist explores the science of love. What can the social and life sciences tell us about the most fundamental and unquantifiable human experience? Drawing on biology, chemistry, and neuroscience all the way up to psychology, sociology, and evolution.



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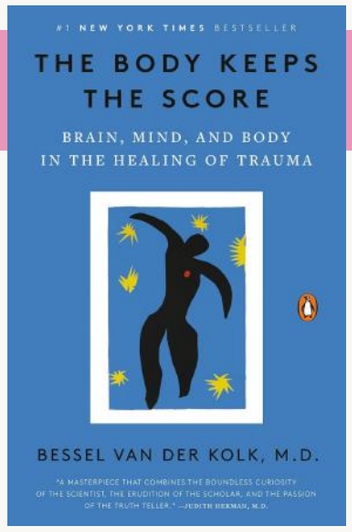
THE BODY KEEPS THE SCORE: BRAIN, MIND, AND BODY IN THE HEALING OF TRAUMA

Bessel van den Kolk



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Trauma, Life History, Psychology

One of the world's foremost experts on trauma uses scientific advances to show how trauma literally reshapes both body and brain, compromising sufferers' capacities for pleasure, engagement, self-control, and trust. He explores innovative treatments—from neurofeedback and meditation to sports, drama, and yoga - that offer new paths to recovery by activating the brain's natural neuroplasticity

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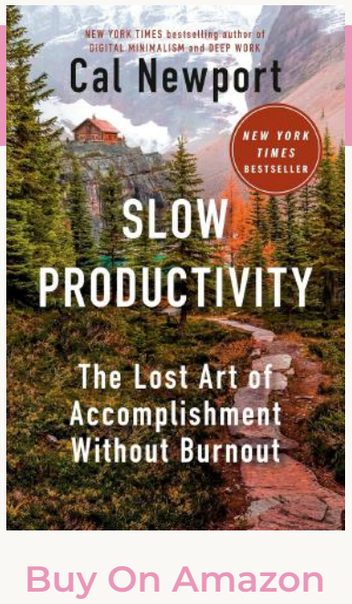
SLOW PRODUCTIVITY: THE LOST ART OF ACCOMPLISHMENT WITHOUT BURNOUT Cal Newport

Productivity, Mindfulness, Intentional Life Strategy

For fans of Oliver Burkeman. A productivity book for people sick of productivity. How psychology, neuroscience, productivity research and history's greatest thinkers use a slower approach to productivity to enjoy life more, increase fulfilment and improve the quality of their work.



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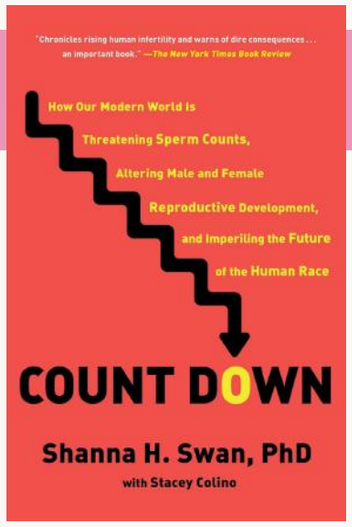
COUNT DOWN: HOW OUR MODERN WORLD IS THREATENING SPERM COUNTS, ALTERING MALE AND FEMALE REPRODUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT, AND IMPERILING THE FUTURE OF THE HUMAN RACE

Dr. Shanna Swan



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Population Collapse, Biology, History

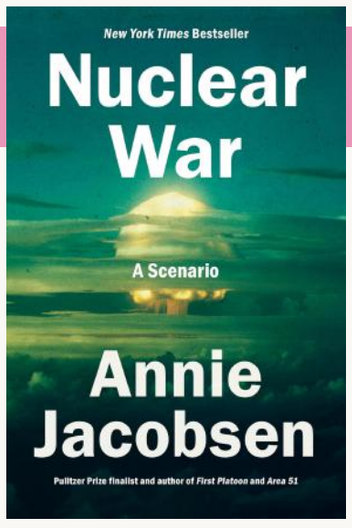
Terrifying and fascinating. In 2017, Shanna's study found that over the past four decades, sperm levels among men in Western countries have dropped by more than 50 percent. But more than that, it turns out our sexual development is changing in broader ways, for both men and women and even other species, and that the modern world is on pace to become an infertile one.

NUCLEAR WAR: A SCENARIO

Annie Jacobsen

Nuclear War-Game, World War, Existential Risk

A minute by minute breakdown of what happens if everyone fires their nukes around the world. Harrowing and stark run-throughs of just how the world might be destroyed. Particularly worrying if you think we're already out of woods with nuclear threats.



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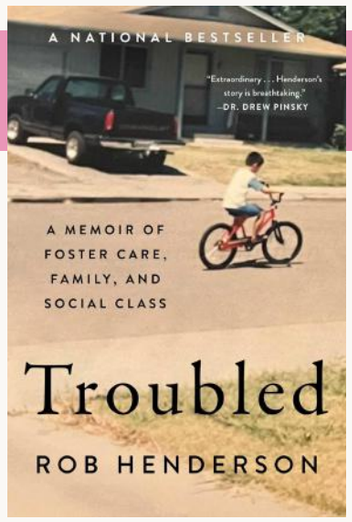
TROUBLED: A MEMOIR OF FOSTER CARE, FAMILY, AND SOCIAL CLASS

Rob Henderson



Memoir, Psychology, Development

From a drug-addicted mother and a father he never met to Yale and Cambridge. A wonderful reflection on life in the underclass, and a journey to changing direction through self-authorship, effort and willpower. I love Rob, his story is great.

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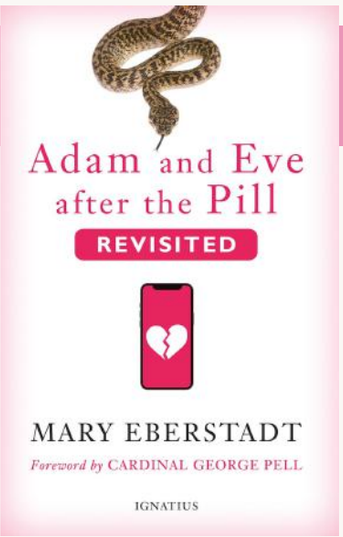
ADAM AND EVE AFTER THE PILL: PARADOXES OF THE SEXUAL REVOLUTION

Mary Eberstadt

Feminism, Mating Dynamics, Social Psychology

How did the introduction of the pill and the sexual revolution take a toll on Western society? From fractured homes to feral children, and social isolates. An indictment of the turn taken by much of the world following the post-1960s embrace of contraception and the stigmatisation of traditional morality.



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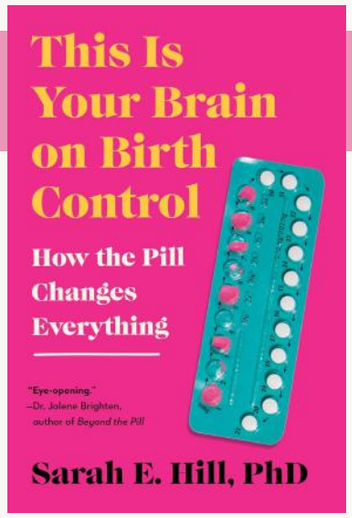
THIS IS YOUR BRAIN ON BIRTH CONTROL: HOW THE PILL CHANGES EVERYTHING Dr. Sarah Hill



Women's Health, Birth Control, Evolutionary Psychology

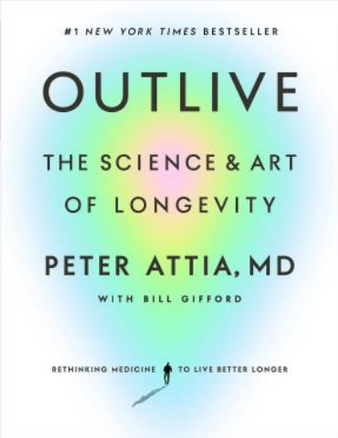
Groundbreaking. A paradigm shift in understanding what one of the most widely distributed medications on the planet does to people. From influencing attraction, sexual motivation, stress, hunger, eating patterns, emotion regulation, friendships, aggression, mood, learning, and more. So readable and interesting.

Buy On Amazon

OUTLIVE: THE SCIENCE AND ART OF LONGEVITY

Dr. Peter Attia

Longevity, Health, Evidence-Based



An operating manual for living longer and better. Technical and deep. Tons of strategies and specifics for how you can optimise every area of your physical and mental health. Drawing on the latest science to deliver innovative nutritional interventions, techniques for optimising exercise and sleep, and tools for addressing emotional and mental health

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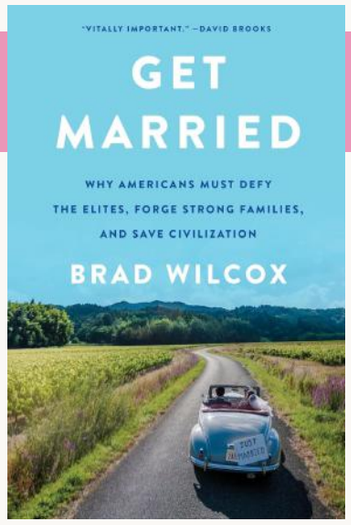
GET MARRIED: WHY AMERICANS MUST DEFY THE ELITES, FORGE STRONG FAMILIES, AND SAVE CIVILIZATION Brad Wilcox



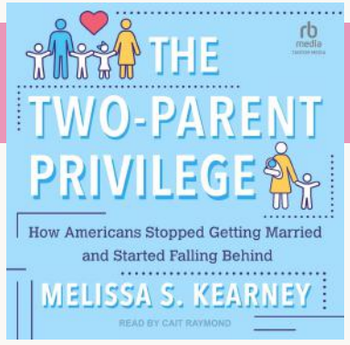
Marriage Advice, Mating Dynamics, Social Psychology

This is a book for anyone who wants to understand why, even as fewer men and women tie the knot, it's still the most reliable route to a life that lasts longer, is happier, healthier and wealthier. Evidence-based techniques for maintaining marital satisfaction and how to build a strong family.

Buy On Amazon

THE TWO-PARENT PRIVILEGE: HOW AMERICANS STOPPED GETTING MARRIED AND STARTED FALLING BEHIND Melissa S. Kearney

Family Advice, Developmental Psychology, Social Psychology

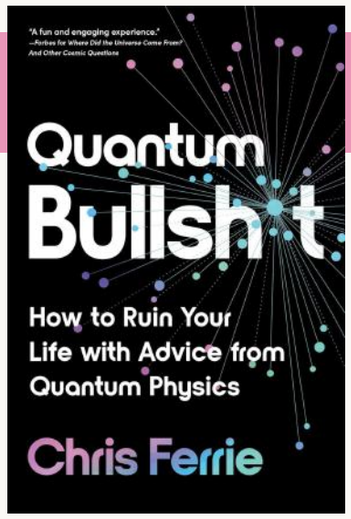


A data-driven case for marriage by showing how the institution's decline has led to a host of economic woes—problems that have fractured society and rendered vulnerable populations even more vulnerable. If you want to understand the trends we're seeing all around us, plus a strong and happy family, and future, this is an important read.

Buy On Amazon

QUANTUM BULLSH*T: HOW TO RUIN YOUR LIFE WITH ADVICE FROM QUANTUM PHYSICS

Chris Ferrie



Debunking, Quantum Physics, Manifestation

A great pushback against much of the awful claims peddled by people who claim to understand how Quantum Physics works. Crystals? Aligning your quantum energy? Mystical distant connections? A great rebuttal to dreadful “science”.

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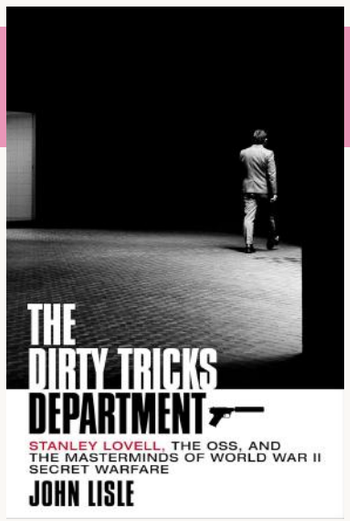
THE DIRTY TRICKS DEPARTMENT: STANLEY LOVELL, THE OSS, AND THE MASTERMINDS OF WORLD WAR II SECRET WARFARE

John Lisle

World War 2, History, Hilarious Stories

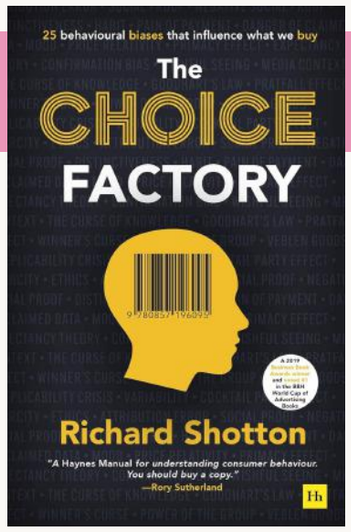


Another absolute sleeper. How did the predecessor to the CIA invent Bat Bombs, suicide pills, fighting knives, silent pistols, and camouflaged explosives? Plus how they forged documents for undercover agents, plotted the assassination of foreign leaders, and performed truth drug experiments on unsuspecting subjects.

Buy On Amazon

THE CHOICE FACTORY: 25 BEHAVIOURAL BIASES THAT INFLUENCE WHAT WE BUY

Richard Shotton



Behavioural Science, Consumer Behaviour, Advertising

25 short chapters explaining some of the most fundamental psychological biases humans have that impact their spending and consumption habits. If you're interested in human nature, marketing or advertising, this is a secret weapon bible.

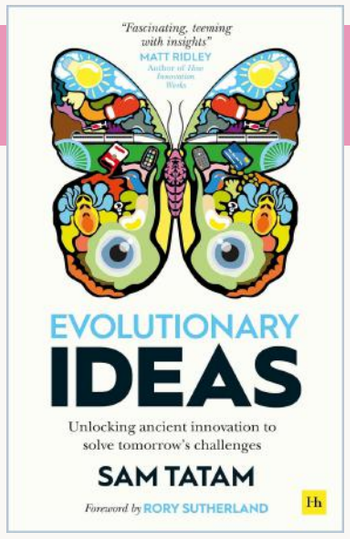
Buy On Amazon

EVOLUTIONARY IDEAS: UNLOCKING ANCIENT INNOVATION TO SOLVE TOMORROW'S CHALLENGES

Sam Tatam

Evolutionary Science, Behavioural Science, Engineering

How do solutions from nature show up in real world inventions? From how Japanese engineers reduced bullet train noise by studying owls, how Disney improved the queueing experience in the same way Houston airport made arrivals feel faster (while making people walk further). Why the chocolate at the bottom of a Cornetto ice cream can improve an Error 404 message, and what a bowl of M&Ms has in common with a canary in a coal mine.



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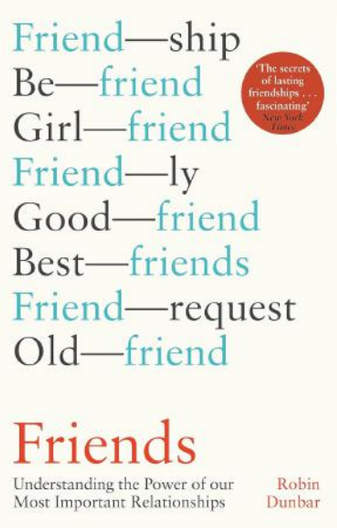
FRIENDS: UNDERSTANDING THE POWER OF OUR MOST IMPORTANT RELATIONSHIPS

Robin Dunbar



Evolutionary Psychology, Social Psychology, Connection

Why and how are friendships so important? How do they influence our lives and health? What are some of the weirdest insights about how human friendship works? Using psychology, anthropology, neuroscience and genetics, one of my favourite writers in evolutionary psychology runs through some amazing lessons.

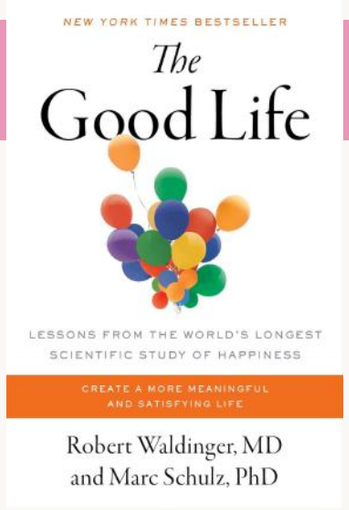
Buy On Amazon

THE GOOD LIFE: LESSONS FROM THE WORLD'S LONGEST SCIENTIFIC STUDY OF HAPPINESS

Dr. Robert Waldinger

Happiness, Self-Development, Evidence-Based

What makes a life fulfilling and meaningful? The longest scientific study on happiness found out the answer: relationships. The stronger our relationships, the more likely we are to live happy, satisfying, and healthier lives. Why? What sort of relationships? And how can we cultivate more of them?



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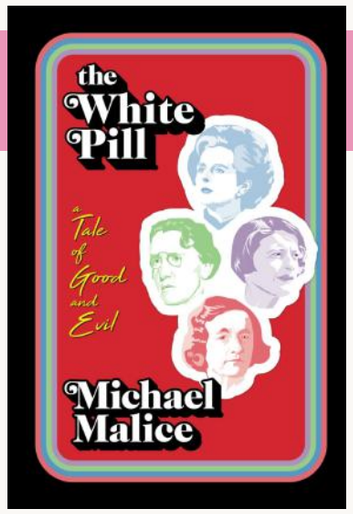
THE WHITE PILL: A TALE OF GOOD AND EVIL

Michael Malice



Soviet Russia, History, Hopecore

I had no idea just how bad the Russian Revolution was. Or why it happened. Or what occurred. This is a harrowing retelling of perhaps the darkest period in human history with a great takeaway - the bad guys don't always win, even when times are worse than they've ever been. An amazing primer for Soviet-era history.

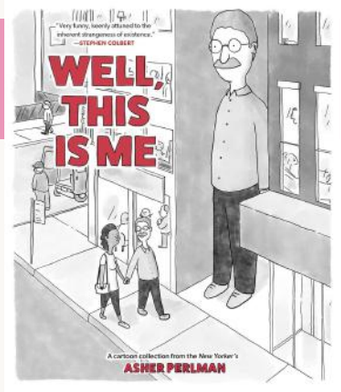
Buy On Amazon

WELL, THIS IS ME: A CARTOON COLLECTION FROM THE NEW YORKER'S ASHER PERLMAN

Asher Perlman

Cartoons, Witty, Humour

My favourite cartoonist made a collection of his best pieces of work. Insanely witty and charming. Every page is basically IG-story-worthy. Heartwarming, raw, hilarious stuff.



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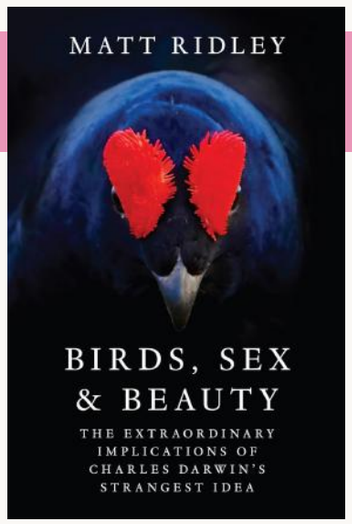
BIRDS, SEX AND BEAUTY: THE EXTRAORDINARY IMPLICATIONS OF CHARLES DARWIN'S STRANGEST IDEA Matt Ridley



Ornithology, Evolutionary Psychology, Sexual Selection

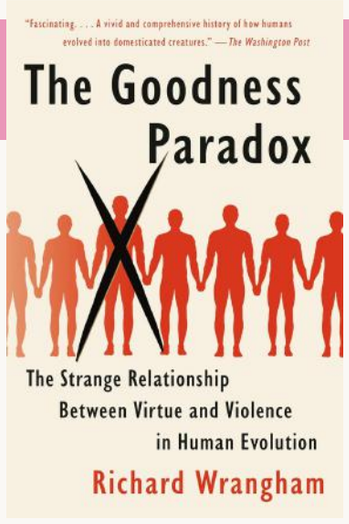
How has female choice shaped the male form? Matt uses examples of the incredible plumage, dances, displays and behaviour of birds to explain how a survival of the hottest has changed the trajectory of all species, humans included.

Buy On Amazon

THE GOODNESS PARADOX: THE STRANGE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN VIRTUE AND VIOLENCE IN HUMAN EVOLUTION Dr. Richard Wrangham

Evolutionary Psychology, Aggression, Human Nature

We Homo sapiens can be the nicest of species and also the nastiest. What occurred during human evolution to account for this paradox? What are the two kinds of aggression that primates are prone to, and why did each evolve separately? How does the intensity of violence among humans compare with the aggressive behaviour of other primates? How did humans domesticate themselves? A great dive into our history of aggression psychology.



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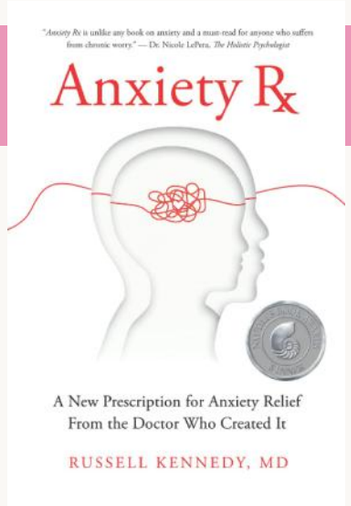
ANXIETY RX: A NEW PRESCRIPTION FOR ANXIETY RELIEF FROM THE DOCTOR WHO CREATED IT

Dr. Russell Kennedy



Anxiety, Mental Health, Practical Advice

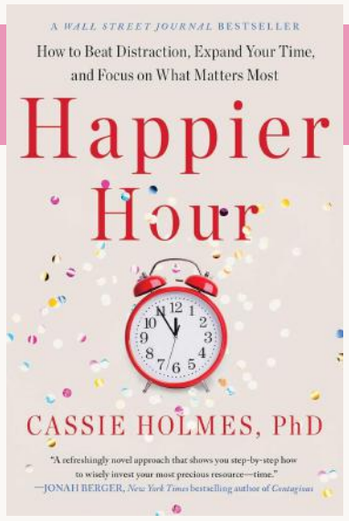
A great explainer of the causes of anxiety and practical steps to reduce it. Advice on how to identify your alarm and anxiety triggers. How to worry less. How to heal, reduce negative loops and intrusive thoughts. Very simply written and tactical.

Buy On Amazon

HAPPIER HOUR: HOW TO BEAT DISTRACTION, EXPAND YOUR TIME, AND FOCUS ON WHAT MATTERS MOST Dr. Cassie Holmes

Time Management, Happiness, Life Balance

Based on a wildly popular MBA class at UCLA. How to design your calendar and life to actually be happy. The best ways to create a schedule with purpose. How to savour moments of joy and sidestep distractions. Practical and meaningful insights.



Buy On Amazon

GOOD REASONS FOR BAD FEELINGS: INSIGHTS FROM THE FRONTIER OF EVOLUTIONARY PSYCHIATRY

Randolph M. Nesse

Evolutionary Psychology, Mental Health, Psychiatry

A new explanation and understanding of why human mental health can be so turbulent and painful. What are the evolutionary reasons for why we feel the things we do? If you want to better understand your emotions and have a new sense of perspective, this is awesome.

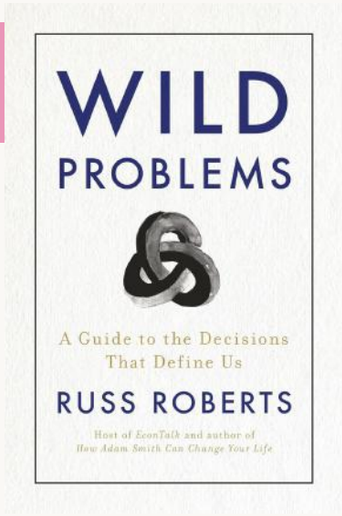
Buy On Amazon

WILD PROBLEMS: A GUIDE TO THE DECISIONS THAT DEFINE US

Russ Roberts

Economics, Life Design, Big Questions

Algorithms and apps analyse data and tell you how to beat the traffic, what books to buy, what music to listen to, and even who to date—often with great results. But what do you do when you face the big decisions of life—the "wild problems" of who to marry, whether to have children, where to move, how to forge a life well-lived—that can't be solved by measurement or calculation? An economist answers.



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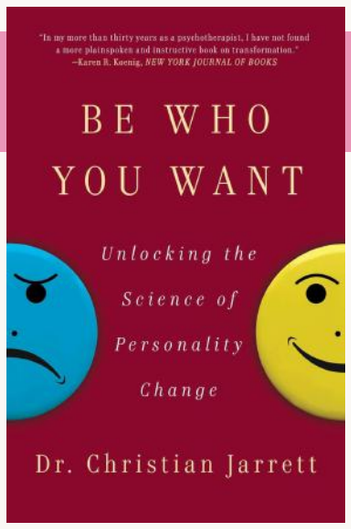
BE WHO YOU WANT: UNLOCKING THE SCIENCE OF PERSONALITY CHANGE Dr. Christian Jarrett



Personality Science, Personal Development, Psychology

How malleable are our personalities? How can we change our lives from the inside-out? What does the latest science say about just how much stuff we can change and how much we can't? Filled with quizzes and interactive exercises to help you better understand the various aspects of your personality. Practical and fascinating.

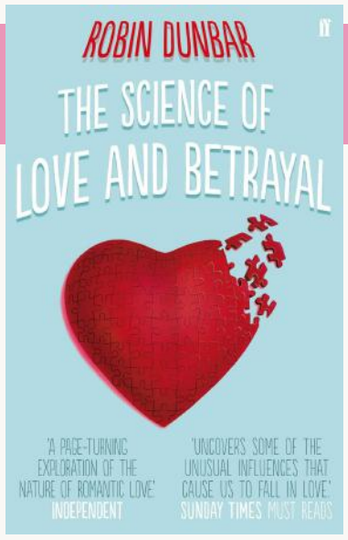
Buy On Amazon

THE SCIENCE OF LOVE AND BETRAYAL

Robin Dunbar

Evolutionary Psychology, Romance, Mating Dynamics

Falling in love is one of the strangest things we can do - and one of the things that makes us uniquely human. But what happens to our brains when our eyes meet across a crowded room? Why do we kiss each other, forget our friends, seek a 'good sense of humour' and try (and fail) to be monogamous? How are our romantic relationships different from our relationships with friends, family or even God?



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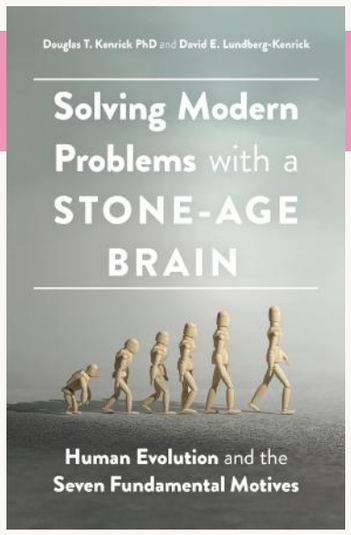
SOLVING MODERN PROBLEMS WITH A STONE-AGE BRAIN: HUMAN EVOLUTION AND THE SEVEN FUNDAMENTAL MOTIVES

Dr. Douglas T. Kenrick & David E. Lundberg-Kenrick



Evolutionary Psychology, Environmental Mismatch, Self-Understanding

How does evolutionary mismatch between our ancestral environment and the modern world we find ourselves in cause all manner of issues? How is our brain always fighting against the stimuli of the modern world to be attacked by marketers peddling sugar-laden foods, pundits fanning the culture war flames, and payday loan companies scamming those who can least afford it.

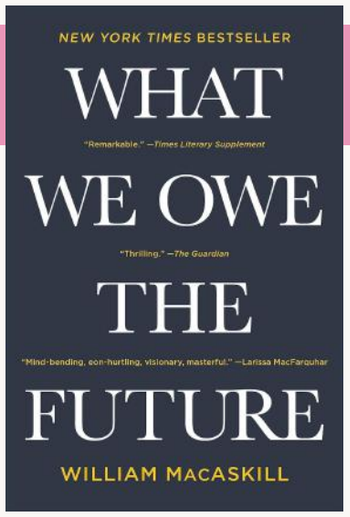
Buy On Amazon

WHAT WE OWE THE FUTURE

William MacAskill

Longtermism, Effective Altruism, Human Futures

The fate of the world – and the future – is in our hands. Longtermism argues that positively influencing the distant future is our time's key moral priority. It's not enough to reverse climate change or avert a pandemic. We must ensure that civilisation would rebound if it collapsed; counter the end of moral progress; and prepare for a planet where the smartest beings are digital.



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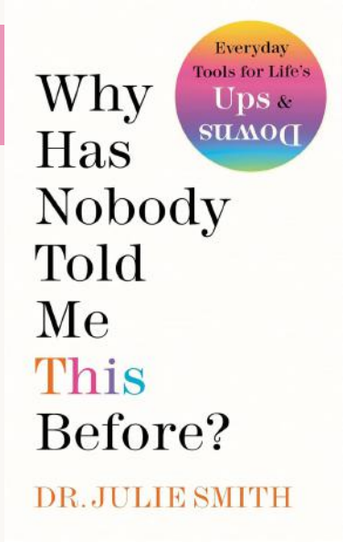
WHY HAS NOBODY TOLD ME THIS BEFORE?

Dr. Julie Smith



Psychology, Life Advice, Practical Tools

A therapist's toolkit to manage anxiety, deal with criticism, cope with depression, build self-confidence, find motivation and learn to forgive yourself. It tackles everyday issues and offers practical solutions in bite-sized, easy-to-digest entries which make it easy to quickly find specific information and guidance.

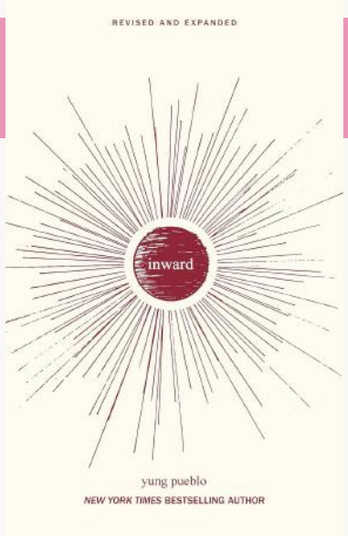
Buy On Amazon

INWARD

Yung Pueblo

Poetry, Mindfulness, Self-Love

A collection of poetry and prose that explores the movement from self-love to unconditional love, the power of letting go, and the wisdom that comes when we truly try to know ourselves. A gentle reminder that healing, transformation, and freedom are possible. Terse, beautiful.



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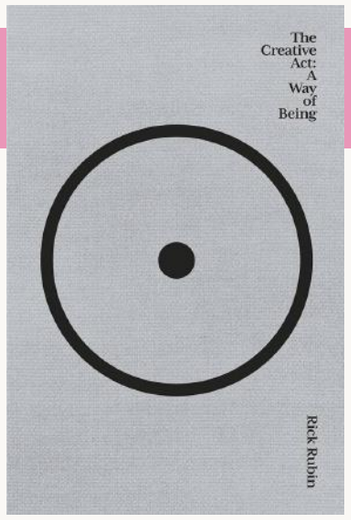
THE CREATIVE ACT: A WAY OF BEING

Rick Rubin



Creativity, Artistic Inspiration, Deep Wisdom

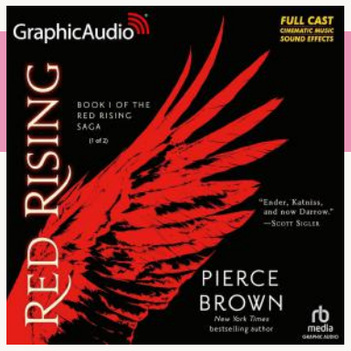
A legendary music producer's advice for creating great art, connecting to your work, being at peace with yourself and staying true in a world which always tries to lead you astray. Simple, impactful, deep. Like reading a reassuring, inspiring hug.

Buy On Amazon

FICTION

RED RISING (PART 1 OF 2) (DRAMATIZED ADAPTATION): RED RISING, BOOK 1

Pierce Brown



Listen on Audible

Science Fiction, Fantasy, Insanely Addictive

My favourite fiction series is brought to life with a full cast of actors, beautiful soundscaping and a ton of amazing audio effects. GraphicAudio basically creates a movie inside of your mind and this book is the perfect one to do it with. Amazing whether you've already read this book or not.

LEXICON

Max Barry

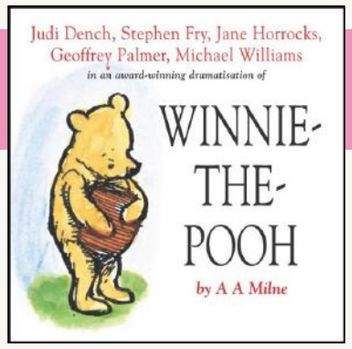
Science Fiction, Clever Wordplay, Thriller

Fire. Straight fire. Specially trained people can use words to persuade others to do whatever they want. Naturally there's a huge struggle for power and a war of words begins. Written in a super witty, charming, easy-to-read way.

Buy On Amazon

WINNIE THE POOH (DRAMATISED)

A. A. Milne



Fiction, Childhood Nostalgia, Calming

Stephen Fry and a full cast bring this book to life in glorious fashion. Peaceful, gentle, loving. Nothing to remember or learn, just a wonderfully reassuring tale about a child and his bear :)

Listen on Audible

MYTHOS: (ANCIENT GREEK MYTHOLOGY BOOK FOR ADULTS, MODERN TELLING OF CLASSICAL GREEK MYTHS BOOK)

(STEPHEN FRY'S GREEK MYTHS, 1)

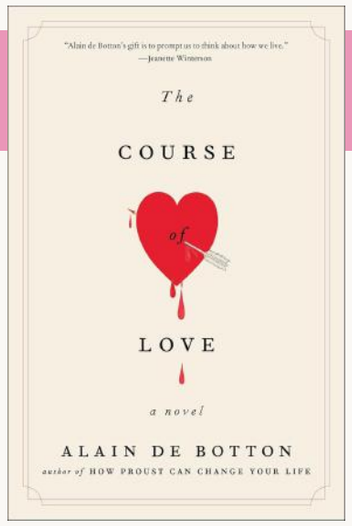
Stephen Fry

History, Ancient Greece, Witty

A modern collection of Greek myths, stylishly retold by Stephen Fry in his amazing voice. This transforms the adventures of Zeus and the Olympians into emotionally resonant and deeply funny stories, without losing any of their original wonder. Great to fall asleep to.

Buy On Amazon

THE COURSE OF LOVE
Alain de Botton



Novel, Romance, Deep Human Psychology

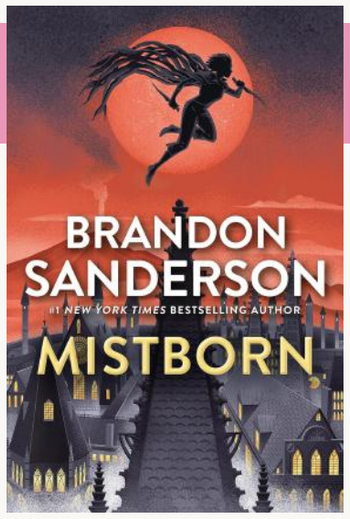
Alain steps into the fiction world to break down a very normal imaginary relationship which goes through all the vicissitudes of love, romance and the course of life thereafter. Wonderfully crafted and philosophically relevant.

Buy On Amazon

MISTBORN
Brandon Sanderson

Fantasy, Fast-Paced, Alternate Universes

One of the most popular modern fantasy series. 7 books to get through, huge world-building, complex lore and history. Fantastic if you want to lose yourself in something for a few months.



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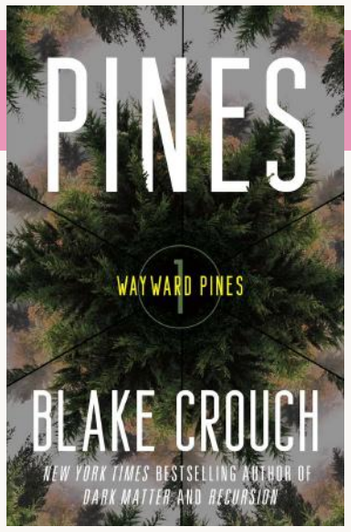
WAYWARD PINES TRILOGY

Blake Crouch



Thriller, Science Fiction, Future Worlds

Super action packed. Really easy read and keeps moving. Guy wakes up in hospital, unsure why, all hell breaks loose. Very hard to describe without ruining the trilogy unfortunately but it's worth it. Great holiday read.

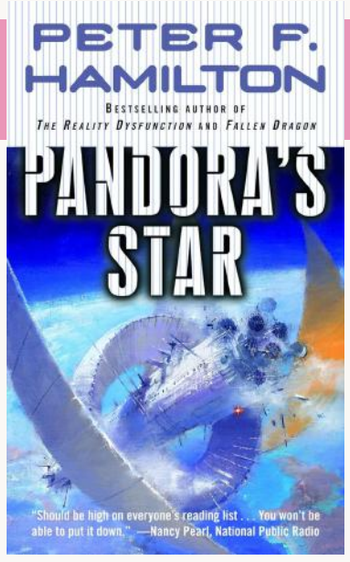
Buy On Amazon

PANDORA'S STAR

Peter F. Hamilton

Sci-Fi, Whodunnit, Space Exploration

In the future, over a thousand light years away, a star disappears. A five-times-rejuvenated ex-NASA pilot, is dispatched to learn what has occurred and whether it represents a threat. Awesome open loops and massive environment.



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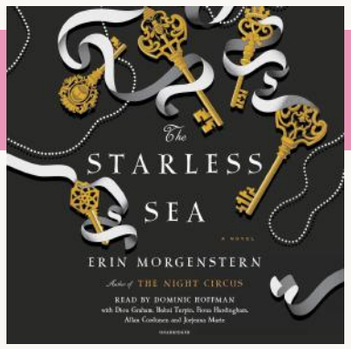
THE STARLESS SEA
Erin Morgenstern



Listen on Audible

Psychedelic, Lost Cities, Mystery

Honestly, I don't quite know what this is about, but the Audible is amazing. Fantastic buttery narration, lovely deep voice and a gentle tones. I usually fall asleep within 20 minutes but the story is always kind and reassuring.

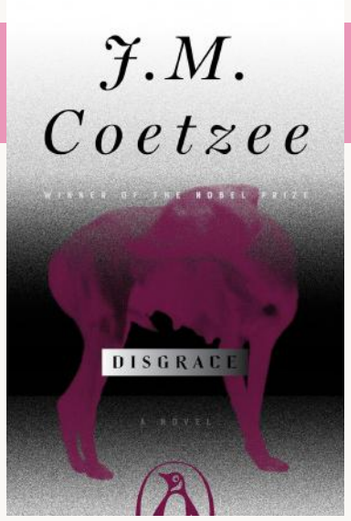
THE CHRISTMAS PIG (AUDIOBOOK)
J.K Rowling

Heartwarming, Children's Tale, Festive

Nothing complex to see here. A cute tale about a young boy growing up, loving his stuffed animal and navigating a broken home. Wonderfully sound designed on Audible.

Listen on Audible

DISGRACE
J.M. Coetzee



Life Journey, Fatherhood, Existential Crises

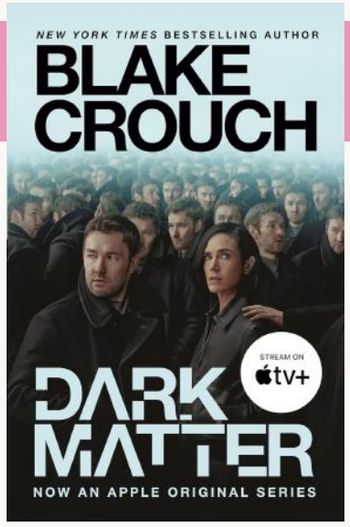
52-year-old Professor David Lurie has affair with a student, leaving him jobless, gets shunned by friends, and ridiculed by his ex-wife, he retreats to his daughter Lucy's smallholding to attempt to find meaning in his one remaining relationship. Complex, insightful, dark.

Buy On Amazon

DARK MATTER
Blake Crouch

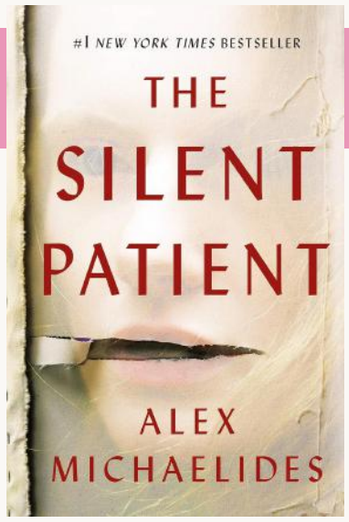
Science Fiction, Mind-Bending, Mystery

Guy wakes up after being kidnapped in a world where his wife is not his wife, his son was never born and he’s not an ordinary college professor but a celebrated genius. Everything goes wrong. He has to survive. Super fast paced easy read.



Buy On Amazon

THE SILENT PATIENT
Alex Michaelides



Thriller, Mystery, Psychological Insight

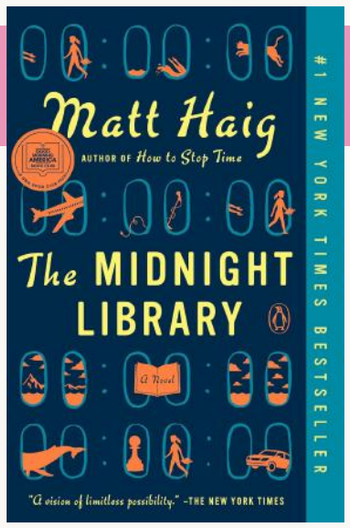
Famous painter shoots her husband 5 times in the face then doesn't speak again. Criminal psychotherapist tries to uncover what happened while his own life unravels. Great twists, motivating read.

Buy On Amazon

THE MIDNIGHT LIBRARY
Matt Haig

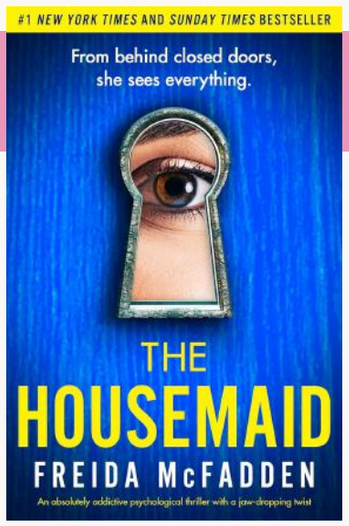
Thriller, Feel-Good, Reassuring Story

250,000+ reviews on Amazon. Such a feel-good story about a woman who dies and visits a library which shows her all the different lives she could have lived - where she followed a different career, avoided old breakups or realised her dreams of becoming an athlete. Perfect holiday read.



Buy On Amazon

THE HOUSEMAID
Freida McFadden



Thriller, Romance, Psychological Mystery

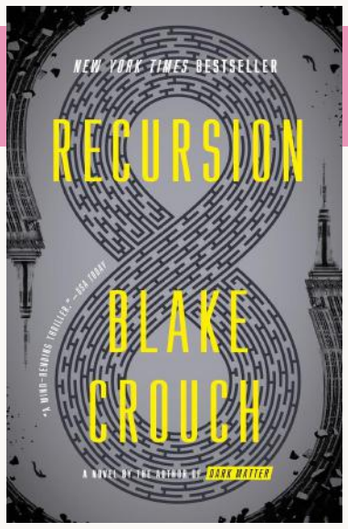
500,000 reviews on Amazon. Monster. Super simple read about a housemaid who starts working for a kind husband and his bitch wife. Romantic complications + mortal danger ensues. Huge twists throughout and a dark undertone.

Buy On Amazon

RECURSION
Blake Crouch

Science Fiction, Memory, Time

Awesome story about a world where a disease spreads through an unknown method that drives its victims mad with memories of a life they never lived. If you like thinking about time, memory and easy-to-read science fiction, you'll love this.



Buy On Amazon